

In Excel, **Date functions** are essential for managing timelines, calculating durations, and organizing schedules within your workbooks. Since you are working on various engineering and data projects, these functions can help automate deadlines and project tracking.

1. DATE(year, month, day)

This function creates a valid Excel date from three separate numbers.

- **Example:** `=DATE(2026, 5, 27)` returns the date **27-05-2026**, which is helpful for standardizing inputs from separate columns.

2. TODAY() and NOW()

These are volatile functions that update every time your sheet calculates.

- **TODAY():** Returns the current system date. For instance, `= "Today's Date: " & TEXT(TODAY(), "dd-mm-yyyy")` provides a dynamic header for a report.
- **NOW():** Returns the current date and the exact time. This is often used for logging when a specific entry was made.

3. DATEDIF(start_date, end_date, unit)

A powerful "hidden" function used to calculate the difference between two dates in specific units like years ("y"), months ("m"), or days ("d").

- **Example:** `=DATEDIF(DATE(2024, 6, 1), DATE(2024, 8, 31), "m")` would return **2**, which could represent the duration of a summer internship.

4. EDATE(start_date, months)

This function returns a date that is a specific number of months before or after a start date.

- **Example:** If a project is due 3 months after February 27th, `=EDATE("27-02-2026", 3)` returns **27-05-2026**.

5. NETWORKDAYS(start_date, end_date, [holidays])

Calculates the number of full working days (excluding weekends) between two dates.

- **Example:** Use this to calculate how many actual workdays remain before a specific project deadline.

6. YEAR, MONTH, and DAY

These functions extract individual components from a single date.

- **YEAR(A1):** Returns the four-digit year (e.g., **2026**).
- **MONTH(A1):** Returns the month number (1 to 12).
- **DAY(A1):** Returns the day of the month (1 to 31).

Quick Tips for Date Data

- **Date Format Shortcut:** Use **Ctrl + Shift + #** to quickly format a number as a date.
- **Timestamp Shortcut:** Press **Ctrl + ;** (semicolon) to insert a static current date that won't change later.
- **Date Logic:** In Excel, dates are stored as serial numbers (starting with 1 for Jan 1, 1900), allowing you to perform simple math like `=TODAY() + 7` to find the date one week from now.